

BANDEEP SINGH



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1. Multiple Agencies at Cross-purposes

Bengaluru has a maze of governmental, parastatal and autonomous bodies to govern and provide its citizens infrastructure and civic amenities, with no unified command to monitor, regulate and coordinate its growth (see *Too Many Monitors*). Foremost among them is the Bangalore Metropolitan Region Development Authority (BMRDA), which oversees the development of three districts—Bengaluru Urban and Rural and Ramanagara—totalling 8,000 sq. km, making it possibly the largest among India's metropolitan regions. The BMRDA was formed to coordinate the activities of the various civic agencies in these districts, but lack of financial powers have rendered it a largely toothless body that cannot enforce its diktats.

Then, there is the Bangalore Development Authority (BDA), an autonomous body meant to prepare the master plan for the city and oversee its orderly growth. Shockingly, however, the city's last master plan expired in 2015 and it has not got a new one even after seven years. The BDA had prepared a plan for 2015 to 2031, but the state's urban development department (UDD), which the planning body reports to, summarily rejected it and asked for a revised plan incorporating the transport development framework prepared by the UDD's directorate of urban land transport. Why it wasn't incorporated in the first place is a telling example of how these agencies operate in silos.

Other examples of agencies working in isolation are the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTC), which oversees the city's land transport, and the Bangalore Metro Rail Corporation (BMRC). They are housed in the same office complex in Shantinagar but don't work in coordination. The BMTC reports to the state's transport ministry and operates independently of other civic agencies

CITIZENSPEAK

'Bring the public into public infrastructure'

NARESH V. NARASIMHAN, *60*
Principal Architect, VA

Narasimhan wears many hats–architect, entrepreneur, urbanist and activist. Having grown up in Bengaluru, he has decided to actively engage in solving the city's woes. Among them was the dismal state of major storm drains, or rajakaluves. Over the years, silt has reduced their flow capacity by a third, and garbage dumped into these drains as well as sewage and illegally released industrial effluents have compounded the problem. Come rain and the drains overflow. Two years ago, Narasimhan got MOD, a non-profit that he co-founded, to collaborate with the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP) and map out the contours of one of the worst maintained stormwater drains. Originating in Majestic, the city centre, it flowed into the Bellanduru Lake in the Koramangala Valley 12 km away, with a watershed of 32 sq. km and accounting for 12 per cent of the city's rainwater run-off. Inspired by an example from Seoul city, BBMP, with the help of MOD, got down to restoring K-100, as it was named. That included removing 900 truckloads of silt, in addition to reworking the piped drainage system. The project cost Rs 150 crore. With the gradient restored, stormwater began to flow freely; during the recent floods, there was no overflow in the surrounding areas. "This is an example of how we can move from a grey to a green infrastructure," says Narasimhan. "And also of how we must bring the public into public infrastructure."